way to the most sought-after OT nurses," he says. There are also upskilling programmes that enable nurses to move into management, become nurse trainers or seek opportunities abroad, including in West Asia and the UK.

But not every talent gap can be fixed through corporate initiatives. Some barriers run much deeper in India's social and cultural fabric, particularly the way the country views manual work. There is a huge skill gap in hands-on trades such as electrical and plumbing work because of what Dewan of JustJobs Network calls India's strong "head over hand" bias, in which manual trades and blue-collar work are seen as less valuable. Quess estimates that the shortage of skilled-trade workers, including plumbers and electricians, will widen to 1.3 million by 2031. "No parent aspires for their kid to become a carpenter or an electrician. Those are seen as fallback jobs," says Dewan. But the reality is that white-collar jobs are also shrinking and becoming more specialised. "In this age of AI," Dewan adds, "cognitive jobs will become fewer and fewer, and manual trades will actually grow in importance. So, we need to raise both the quality of the trade itself and ensure policy focuses on improving the social perception of those trades."

Chief economic advisor V. Anantha Nageswaran echoed this shift when he recently spoke about the changing prospects for software jobs and the need to value skilled trades such as welding, plumbing, electrical work and carpentry. The country, he said, should view these skills with dignity and respect. "It's about trade skills. It's about soft skills, which AI cannot easily replace, where human presence is required."

Changing this perception will require not just curricula and teachers but also counselling and communication. Students and their parents are often unaware of the career pathways skilling can open up over the next 10-20 years—from working as an electrician in Germany to becoming a caregiver in Japan. It is only when students buy into these possibilities, says Bhardwaj of FISME, that skilling courses will generate demand. Skilling is often pushed from the top; it will gain traction only when it answers to students' aspirations, capabilities and interests. "The main customer of skilling programmes is the student, and hence it is important to understand what their aspirations are," he says.

MISMATCH 5

THE CHASM OF GEOGRAPHY

Most large-scale manufacturing in India is concentrated in Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Gujarat and Delhi-NCR, while most labour is from Bihar, Jharkhand, Odisha and Chhattisgarh. The jobs thus are not where the people are. Nitin Dave, chief executive officer of Quess Staffing, says migration is particularly difficult for workers at the start of their careers when they have never ventured beyond their villages. Besides the financial cost of moving and the lack of safe housing, there are "the softer aspects of moving away from peers and family, staying in a different culture, eating different food", says Dave, adding that such issues are magnified for women workers.

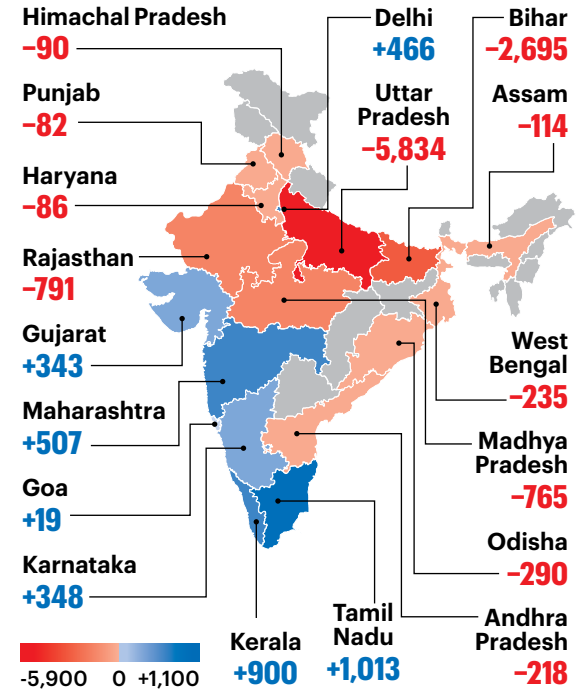
Increasingly, therefore, many workers are gravitating towards delivery jobs instead of factory work because they are closer to home, offer greater flexibility and provide immediate earning potential. "We are extensively counselling workers on the long-term career and earnings growth path of working in a factory," says Dave. "We tell our 1,200 recruiters that they have to sell the future to a candidate, not a job."

India has the world's largest working-age population, an advantage many other countries can only aspire to match. To make the most of this demographic dividend requires addressing education, employability and employment together, says Sabharwal of TeamLease Services. A candidate's employability cannot improve without reforming education; but even if education improves, employment outcomes ultimately depend on the availability of productive jobs in the market. "Education, employment, employability cannot be unpacked," he says. India must strengthen the entire continuum—from strong foundational skills and ITIs that teach what industry needs to the creation of jobs youth can aspire to. Miss any link and the chain breaks. The demographic dividend could then turn into frustration and social unrest, a glimpse of which we saw this summer at Jantar Mantar. ■

THE LABOUR DIVIDE

Maharashtra, Kerala and Tamil Nadu attract the most young migrants, while Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan see large outflows

NET MIGRANTS, 2001–11 (age 21-29, in '000)



Source: Economic Survey 2016-17 (2011 Census)